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Costs and competitors

What it costs to make, sell and deliver CodeSchool, whether the prices leave a margin, and what competing CT&AI books and platforms contain

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Cost figures are estimates (est.) built from rate trackers and listings, not supplier quotes

Report title: "Channel terms, not prices, decide CodeSchool's margin"

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About this report

No printer, distributor, illustrator or agency quote was obtained: every cost and margin figure marked (est.) is an estimate built from published rates and listings, with its assumptions stated. Competitor contents come from listings and catalogues, not opened books. The last section lists what to confirm directly before committing money.

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Summary

CodeSchool's prices are competitive, but on ordinary trade terms they leave almost no margin. Printing a workbook and supplying a share of a classroom kit should cost about **Rs 90-120 a pack (est.)**, roughly a fifth of the Rs 449 and Rs 599 MRPs. That is in line with large school publishers. The problem is everything else. Distributors and booksellers typically take **45-55% of MRP**, and up to 65% where a school commission has to be funded (All About Book Publishing; IIP Books). After that come returns, bad debts, interest on 140-160 days of credit, specimens, freight and per-school teacher training. In the central case the **Classes 3-5 pack keeps about Rs 15 per student and the Classes 6-8 pack about Rs 38 (est.)**. Recovering about Rs 50 lakh of content cost at that rate would take about 1.9 lakh students, or 700 schools (est.). The prices should stay where they are; the cost structure has to change. If CodeSchool sells through appointed booksellers at about a 35% discount with no school commission, makes kits that last three years, and runs most training in clusters or online, contribution rises to **Rs 123-174 per student (est.)**. Break-even then falls to about 34,000 students, or 125 schools: 0.4% of India's 33,248 CBSE schools. The **Rs 299 + GST school licence is the healthier product**. It avoids the book trade and keeps about **Rs 152 per student (est.)**, but it needs a Rs 20-73 lakh platform and it suits only schools with devices. On the competitor side, the printed CT&AI shelf for 2026-27 is thin. OUP and Goyal sell plain books at Rs 145-305. Uolo's Tekie sells a connected platform from Rs 799. No product page found shows coding indexed to NCERT maths chapters, project rubrics, offline use on shared devices, or a CBSE-style evidence journal. Those four things are the gap CodeSchool can own.

*Conventions. The research date is 10 November 2026, and prices are in Indian rupees (1 lakh = 100,000; 1 crore = 10 million). Every figure marked **(est.)** is this report's own calculation or assumption, not a quote or an official statistic. Dollar figures are converted at an assumed Rs 88 per US dollar. No printer, kit maker, distributor, illustrator or agency was asked for a real quote, so the cost model needs checking against the quotes listed at the end. None of this is tax or legal advice.*

Print and kits cost about a fifth of MRP

A 112-page workbook costs Rs 38-90, depending almost entirely on run length

No Indian printer publishes a rate card for a four-colour A4 workbook, so per-copy costs here are built up from first principles. Paper is the biggest input. Between 24 August and 21 September 2026, maplitho paper sold for **Rs 53-82/kg** and coated art paper for Rs 88-157/kg, with no change since July (Indian Printer & Publisher, Aug/Sept 2026). Paper went up through 2025. Mills announced Rs 2-6/kg increases again in March 2026 (PrintWeek India), but prices remain well below the 2022 peak of about Rs 110/kg. In that peak year, school-book publishers said paper was **about 60% of their costs** (Frontlist).

A 112-page book on 70 gsm maplitho uses about 0.28 kg of paper, worth Rs 18-22 at a mid-market Rs 63-78/kg (Rs 15-23 across the full Rs 53-82/kg range). A laminated 300 gsm cover adds about Rs 5-7, and press and binding add Rs 8-11 on long runs (all est.). Plates and makeready are fixed costs, so short runs cost much more per copy.

Table 1. Per-copy cost of a 112-page A4 four-colour perfect-bound workbook (all est.)

Run per title	Rs per copy	Note
1,000	60-90	Realistic for a pilot or year-one title
5,000	45-65	
20,000	38-52	
50,000	35-48	
Two-colour instead of four	4-8 less	
Full-colour digital	450-900	More than the MRP; not viable

The model builds on old benchmarks. In 2011 NCERT's job rate was Rs 40-45 per 1,000 sheets per side, and printers called the market rate "about double" (PrintWeek India, 2011). A self-publishing guide puts bulk printing at roughly Rs 50-60 a book for 1,000 copies (OrangeBooks). Digital colour costs Rs 4-8 a page even at volume (Printster). A pilot

should therefore be a 1,000-copy offset run, or digital printing in black-and-white or two colours.

The Classes 6-8 pack adds two saddle-stitched project booklets of 24-32 pages each. They cost about Rs 6-12 a pair at 20,000 copies and Rs 15-25 at 1,000 (est.). A 150-200 page teacher script book costs Rs 60-120 on offset or Rs 150-300 printed digitally (est.).

One structural point matters more than any rate. **Six class-wise titles split the volume six ways.** At 10,000 students in year one, each title runs to only about 1,700 copies, which puts CodeSchool in the Rs 60-90 band, not the Rs 38-52 band (est.).

A classroom kit costs Rs 800-2,500 per section

Only marketplace listings were found for kit parts, so these figures are indicative:

- **Floor mat.** Star flex costs Rs 12-40 per sq ft. A 6x6 ft floor grid comes to Rs 430-1,440, and a laminated 8x8 ft vinyl mat to about Rs 2,560 (est.) (Rajesh Company; IndiaMART Chennai).
- **Die-cutting.** One online printer charges **Rs 1.21 a shape plus Rs 275 to set up the die**. Its 350 gsm A3 colour sheets cost Rs 35-46 each, or about Rs 3-6 a card (est.) (Printo estimator).
- **Box.** Corrugated board costs Rs 59-82/kg (Indian Printer & Publisher). A printed kit box therefore costs about Rs 40-120 (est.).

A full section kit comes to **Rs 800-2,000 in materials at small volume**, and up to about Rs 2,500 with a heavy mat (est.). No quotes were found for cipher wheels, rivets or kitting labour.

What matters for margin is how long the kit lasts. At 35 students a section, a Rs 1,400 kit that is replaced every year costs Rs 40 per student. If it lasts three years with some replenishment, the cost falls to about Rs 12-15 (est.).

Freight adds Rs 8-24 per student

Consumer parcel rates run from about Rs 50 for 1 kg within a city to Rs 632 for 5 kg to J&K or the North-East (ClickPost Delhivery calculator). Business part-load works out to about **Rs 20/kg all-in**, or Rs 5-7 per 0.3 kg workbook to a nearby zone. Remote zones cost 1.5-2 times that. Freight carries 5% GST, and kits are charged on volumetric weight (length x width x height in cm, divided by 5,000) (iCarry, May 2026). Including inbound freight from the printer and kit freight, budget about 2-4% of MRP (est.).

The trade takes half the MRP and pays five months later

Default discounts are 45-55%, not the 30-40% assumed earlier

There is no audited dataset of school-book margins. Every source points well above the 30-40% the earlier pricing work assumed:

- A veteran publishing commentator puts school publishers' discounts at **40-65%** of MRP (All About Book Publishing, Oct 2022).
- A general-trade guide gives distributors **40-55%**, with the retailer's 20-35% paid out of that (IIP Books, Feb 2026).
- Bhopal booksellers say they get **under 40%** from publishers, while online sellers get up to 50% (Free Press Journal).

The 30-40% figure is what booksellers keep. It is not what the publisher gives up once a distributor stands between them. For a small publisher, a realistic central assumption is 50% (est.). That cuts net realisation to about **Rs 225 on Rs 449 and Rs 300 on Rs 599**.

School commissions now carry criminal risk

Reported school margins on booklist sales are large:

- **15-40%** commission from publishers and traders, in Andhra Pradesh (The Hans India, 2018).
- **40-50%** alleged by parents in Telangana in June 2025 (Frontlist).

These margins come out of the bookseller's share, which is why publishers' discounts climb to 55-65%. Enforcement has hardened:

- **Madhya Pradesh.** Jabalpur's 2024 action led to FIRs against 51 people over a Rs 4.12 crore "books commission" (The Hitavada, May 2024) and books with fake or duplicate ISBNs. In April 2026 the High Court refused to quash the FIRs (SCC Online; LiveLaw).
- **NHRC.** In April 2026 the commission sent notices to every state about costly private textbooks (PrintWeek).
- **Delhi.** On 1 April 2026 the Directorate of Education barred schools from forcing purchases from specific vendors (Business Today).
- **Maharashtra.** On 2 July 2026 the government promised to act against such schools (Free Press Journal).

A new brand that pays commissions to win booklist slots takes a 55-65% discount and legal exposure at the same time. CodeSchool should refuse to pay them. Its offer should be a published price, a written statement of what the school receives (kits and training), and availability from more than one bookseller.

Specimens, a one-quarter season and slow cash define the year

Publishers leave "as many sample books as possible" with decision-makers (All About Book Publishing). No source says how many copies that means per school. This report assumes 3-10 sets per school and treats specimens and sales incentives as **Rs 15-45 per student (est.)**.

The season is short. S Chand books **80-85% of annual revenue in January-March**. Its receivables were **140 days in FY25 and 160 days in FY26**, inventory was 223 days, and it caps sales returns by policy (S Chand Q4 FY25 call; FY26 call). Navneet's state-board dealer channel collects in 42-90 days (Trendlyne; Value Research).

For a newcomer, this report assumes returns of 5-15% of supply, bad debts of 2-5% and credit cost of 5-7% of revenue. Together that is **12-27% of net revenue lost (est.)**.

Table 2. Cash cycle for one booklist year (timing est. from the sources above)

When	Offline Programme	Online Programme
Oct-Dec	Specimens, demos, teacher meetings	Demos and pilot accounts
Nov-Jan	Book paper and press time; print and assemble kits	Platform release for the new session
Jan-Mar	Supply booksellers on credit	Sign licences
Mar-Apr	Parents buy; unsold stock comes back after April	Invoice the school
Apr-Jul	Teacher training	Training; schools collect fees in instalments
May-Sept	Cash arrives 120-180 days after supply	Payment 60-180 days late is common (LEAD FAQ)

Scale makes this concrete. At 100 schools and 27,000 students, CodeSchool would spend about **Rs 31 lakh on print, kits and freight** between December and February, with kits charged over their two-year life (nearer Rs 40 lakh in a year when every kit is bought new). Its receivables would peak at about **Rs 71 lakh** before collection starts in May (both est., central case). A school licence moves the credit risk from booksellers to schools. Poor receivables management contributed to listed edtech Educomp's insolvency (Mynd Solution).

GST is nil on the book but can cost Rs 21-29 a pack

Since GST 2.0 took effect on 22 September 2025:

- **Printed books (heading 4901) stay nil-rated.** Exercise books (4820) moved from 12% to nil.
- **Printing done with the printer's own paper** is a 5% service (SAC 9989).
- **Uncoated paper bought separately** costs 18%.
- **Corrugated boxes (4819)** are 5%.
- **Board games (9504) and non-electronic puzzles (9503)** fell from 12% to 5%.

Sources: TaxGuru; TaxGarden; ClearTax.

A workbook of questions and answer spaces counts as a "printed book". The Delhi High Court held this in its 2019 *Sonka Publication* ruling (StudyCafe). So the workbook, project booklets and teacher book should all be nil-rated.

Two consequences follow:

- **Input GST becomes a cost.** A nil-rated publisher cannot claim back GST it pays on inputs. The 5% on printing and freight therefore stays in the cost of each pack, and this report's print figures include it. Having the printer supply the paper (5%) is likely cheaper than buying paper at 18% (est.).
- **The kit creates a bundling risk.** If the tax authorities treat workbook plus kit as a *mixed supply*, the whole pack is taxed at the highest rate in it, 5%. On a tax-inclusive MRP that takes **Rs 21 out of Rs 449 and Rs 29 out of Rs 599 (est.)**, more than the whole Classes 3-5 central contribution and three-quarters of the Classes 6-8 one. If they treat it as a *composite supply* led by the book, the pack stays nil.

Pricing the kit as a separate line, or invoicing it to the school, keeps that risk small. Which route is right is the first question for a chartered accountant.

The Online Programme is different. A user licence supplied to a public body was held to be an 18% licensing service, not education (LiveLaw Biz, Odisha AAR). A school therefore pays **Rs 353** per student and cannot recover the tax. Because that output is taxable, CodeSchool should be able to claim credit for GST on hosting and development. If one company sells both programmes, input credit on shared costs has to be split between them (TaxGarden).

Content and platform need about Rs 1 crore up front

Content. No Indian K-12 rate card exists. The proxies are:

- Chapter writing at Rs 15,000-40,000 for a 5,000-7,000-word chapter (Frontlines Media).
- Typesetting and layout (DTP) at Rs 35-50 a page for budget work, against Rs 100-500 on marketplaces (Cinnamon Teal; IndiaMART).
- Hindi translation at Rs 1-8 a word (AIM India; Reverie).
- Illustration at USD 15-30 an hour for Indian freelancers (Freelancer.com). No reliable per-image rupee rate was found.

On that basis one illustrated 96-128 page workbook costs **Rs 3-10 lakh**, and a teacher book Rs 1-3 lakh. Six workbooks plus six teacher books come to **Rs 25-75 lakh one-time**, and a yearly refresh costs 10-20% of that (all est.). Illustration is the least certain line.

Teacher training. Schools expect it free. Many CBSE capacity-building programmes for 2025-26 charge no fee (CBSE Notification 113/2025). The public cost norm was Rs 315 per teacher per day under Samagra Shiksha for 2018-19 (Delhi Samagra Shiksha). Academic trainers in edtech earn Rs 2.1-7 lakh a year (AmbitionBox).

That makes a one-day orientation for 20-30 teachers cost about Rs 5,000-15,000, and an online session under Rs 100 per teacher. One orientation, 2-4 online follow-ups and one visit a year cost **Rs 8,000-25,000 per school** (all est.). Because this is a cost per school, small schools are expensive to serve.

Field sales. Sales executives at education companies earn about Rs 2.2-6.5 lakh (Naukri; AmbitionBox, LEAD School; AmbitionBox, MASAI). With incentives and travel, each costs **Rs 4-9 lakh a year in tier-2 cities** (est.). How many schools one person can cover is unsourced. A working assumption is 80-150 prospects and 10-30 conversions a year (est.).

Platform.

- **Build.** Indian agencies quote USD 20,000-70,000 for an education-app MVP (Solguruz; Debut Infotech). An Android-plus-web block-coding app with a teacher dashboard and offline sync sits in the upper part of that range: **Rs 26-62 lakh**, or Rs 15-35 lakh with a lean in-house team (est.).
- **Hosting.** Cheap at this scale. An AWS t3.medium in Mumbai costs about USD 0.0448 an hour (DoiT), which suggests Rs 15,000-40,000 a month for 10,000 students (est.).
- **Security testing.** A vulnerability assessment and penetration test (VAPT) by a CERT-In-empanelled auditor costs Rs 0.5-3 lakh per platform (TCSA; Qualysec).
- **Data protection.** A legal review under the Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act costs about Rs 1-5 lakh (est.).
- **Software licences.** Free. Blockly and Teachable Machine are Apache 2.0. Scratch's editor code (scratch-gui, scratch-vm, scratch-render) has been AGPL-3.0 since November 2024 (scratch-gui licence), so a modified Scratch editor offered online must publish its source; scratch-blocks is Apache 2.0. MIT also bars using the Scratch name and cat to promote derived products, so a Scratch-based editor needs its own brand (scratch-gui TRADEMARK; npm blockly).

Table 3. Fixed costs (all est.)

Item	Low	Central	High
Content: 6 workbooks + 6 teacher books, incl. Hindi	Rs 25 lakh	Rs 50 lakh	Rs 75 lakh
Platform build + VAPT + DPDP review	Rs 20 lakh	Rs 45 lakh	Rs 73 lakh
Total one-time	**Rs 45 lakh**	**Rs 95 lakh**	**Rs 1.48 crore**
Annual: platform upkeep, hosting, DPDP	Rs 5 lakh	Rs 10 lakh	Rs 20 lakh
Annual: content refresh (10-20%)	Rs 2.5 lakh	Rs 7.5 lakh	Rs 15 lakh
Annual: field executives (3 in the central case)	Rs 12 lakh	Rs 19.5 lakh	Rs 27 lakh
Total annual overhead (excludes founders, office)	**Rs 19.5 lakh**	**Rs 37 lakh**	**Rs 62 lakh**

At default trade terms, Rs 449 and Rs 599 earn almost nothing

Per-student unit economics

Assumptions (all est.):

- **School size.** A typical CBSE school has about 265-270 students in Classes 3-8 (270 is used below), split evenly between the two bands. That is 88 lakh students across 33,248 schools, figures from the earlier market report (CBSE SARAS).
- **Sections.** 35 students per section.
- **Kit.** Kit costs include one teacher book per section. The Classes 6-8 line also carries two project kits a year, which takes that kit to about Rs 2,800-3,000 a section. In the central case the kit is assumed to last two years.
- **Training.** About Rs 5,400 per school in the low case, Rs 12,000 central and Rs 27,000 high (Rs 20, Rs 45 and Rs 100 per student at 270 students). The high case sits above the Rs 8,000-25,000 range estimated later.
- **Leakage.** "Leakage" means returns, bad debts and the cost of credit.
- **Scenarios.** "Low" is the favourable case and "High" the adverse one, so in the High column every input is at its worst at once. That stacking is deliberate: it shows what a small first year can look like.

Table 4. Offline Programme per student per year (Rs, all est.)

Line	3-5 Low	3-5 Central	3-5 High	6-8 Low	6-8 Central	6-8 High
MRP	449	449	449	599	599	599
Channel share (% of MRP)	40%	50%	60%	40%	50%	60%
Net to publisher	**269**	**225**	**180**	**359**	**300**	**240**
Leakage (12% / 18% / 27% of net)	-32	-40	-49	-43	-54	-65
Print, incl. 5% unrecoverable GST	-40	-58	-90	-50	-72	-115
Kit + teacher book share	-15	-30	-69	-24	-46	-89
Freight	-8	-12	-20	-10	-15	-24
Specimens and sales incentives	-15	-25	-40	-18	-30	-45
Training and support	-20	-45	-100	-20	-45	-100
Contribution	**139**	**15**	**-188**	**194**	**38**	**-198**
Contribution, % of MRP	31%	3%	-42%	32%	6%	-33%

Print plus kit is about 20% of MRP in the central case. That matches S Chand's direct material cost of about 32% of net revenue, or roughly 16-19% of MRP, behind its FY25 gross margin of 68% (S Chand Q4 FY25 call). So production cost is not the problem. A 50% channel share, plus training and sales costs that an incumbent spreads across thousands of schools, leaves a newcomer almost nothing.

Table 5. Online Programme per student per year (Rs, all est.)

Line	Low	Central	High
Price ex-GST (school pays Rs 353)	299	299	299
Reseller or agent commission	0%	10%	25%
Net	**299**	**269**	**224**
Collection loss and credit (5% / 10% / 20%)	-15	-27	-45
Hosting and third-party services	-7	-25	-48
Demos and sales incentives	-10	-20	-35
Training and support	-20	-45	-100
Contribution	**247**	**152**	**-4**

The model leaves out any paid generative-AI calls. The low hosting figure assumes about 1 lakh students; at 10,000 students hosting is Rs 18-48 a student. Table 3's annual platform line covers upkeep and DPDP, not per-student hosting. Teachable Machine runs in the browser at no cost. A printed teacher guide would add Rs 3-9 per student.

Break-even

Table 6. Students and schools (at 270 students each) needed to recover costs (all est.)

Case	Cost to recover	Contribution per student	Students	Schools
Offline, low	Content Rs 25 lakh	Rs 166 (blend of 3-5 and 6-8)	15,000	56
Offline, central, default terms	Content Rs 50 lakh	Rs 26.5	1,89,000	700
Offline, central, re-engineered (Table 7)	Content Rs 50 lakh	Rs 148	34,000	125
Offline, high	Content Rs 75 lakh	Negative	Never	n/a

Case	Cost to recover	Contribution per student	Students	Schools
Online, low	Platform Rs 20 lakh	Rs 247	8,100	30
Online, central	Platform Rs 45 lakh	Rs 152	29,600	110
Online, high	Platform Rs 73 lakh	About -Rs 4	Never	n/a
Central annual overhead of Rs 37 lakh	Every year	Offline default / re-engineered / online	1.4 lakh / 25,000 / 24,000	520 / 93 / 90

On default terms, the Offline Programme cannot even pay its own sales team. Three executives converting 20 schools each would bring in about 16,000 students and about Rs 4.3 lakh of contribution, against Rs 19.5 lakh of salaries (est.). The first year will look like the High column: short print runs, new kits and heavy training. Founders should expect a loss on every pack in the pilot year.

What closes the gap, and whether any price should change

Price is a weak lever. At a 50% channel share and 18% leakage, every Rs 50 added to MRP yields only about **Rs 20 of contribution**. Every 10 points cut from the channel share yields **Rs 37 on Rs 449 and Rs 49 on Rs 599** (est.). The levers that matter are structural.

Table 7. Re-engineered central case at today's prices (all est.)

Change	Effect per student
Sell through 2-3 appointed booksellers per city at about a 35% discount, no school commission, with a public parent e-store	Net rises to Rs 292 / Rs 389
Supply in firm per-school quantities to cut returns	Leakage falls to 15% of net (Rs 44 / Rs 58)
Durable kit lasting 3 years, or kit invoiced to the school as a separate 5% supply	Kit line Rs 15 / Rs 25
Cluster and online training instead of repeat school visits	Training Rs 25
One printer, booked Oct-Dec, runs of 10,000+ per title	Print Rs 48 / Rs 62
Resulting contribution	**Rs 123 (27%) on Rs 449; Rs 174 (29%) on Rs 599**

Freight and specimens stay at their central values (Rs 12 / Rs 15 and Rs 25 / Rs 30).

The verdict on prices:

- **Keep Rs 449 and Rs 599.** The market ceiling is Uolo's Tekie.AI at Rs 579-629 on a Lucknow booklist (CMS booklist). The floor is Goyal at about Rs 145-165 for Classes 3-5 and OUP and Goyal at Rs 270-305 for Classes 6-8. Raising the Classes 3-5 pack would widen an already threefold gap to Goyal for very little extra margin. Matching Tekie at Rs 629 for Classes 6-8 would add only about Rs 12.
- **Trim the Classes 3-5 book to 64-80 pages.** CBSE plans only 50 hours a year at this stage, inside Maths and The World Around Us periods (CBSE webinar deck). A slimmer book saves Rs 8-15 (est.).
- **Keep Rs 299 + GST for the licence.** It sits 63% below Tekie's Rs 799 entry price (Uolo). Add a **per-school minimum of about Rs 25,000-30,000 (est.)**, because training costs the same in a 100-student school as in a 400-student one.

The earlier pricing report needs two corrections:

- **Net to CodeSchool.** It put this at Rs 270-315 on Rs 449 and Rs 360-420 on Rs 599, using a 30-40% channel margin. On the evidence here, default terms (45-55% off MRP) give **Rs 202-247 and Rs 270-329**, and the full 40-60% range in Table 4 gives Rs 180-269 and Rs 240-359. The higher figures are reachable only through the appointed-bookseller route in Table 7.

- **Orange.** Its table listed Orange's "Artificial Intelligence" Class 6 book (Rs 289, MRP Rs 340) as a printed CT&AI title. That book is a **Touchpad book for CBSE's Artificial Intelligence skill subject (code 901), not CT&AI**. Orange's 2026-27 catalogue has **no CT&AI series for Classes 3-8** (Orange Catalogue 2026-27; Kitabkopy).

Rivals sell thin books or connected platforms

The printed CT&AI shelf is mostly plain books

CBSE's design is the yardstick. Classes 3-5 get **50 hours a year of CT only, with no AI**, built into Maths and The World Around Us. Classes 6-8 get **100 hours**: 40 hours of CT, 20 of AI and 40 of projects (two a year). The curriculum is "largely unplugged". Assessment is explicitly not "write a program" and does not assume computer access. CBSE still lists project rubrics as "coming soon" (CBSE webinar deck). Its Class 6 handbook keys every CT chapter to an NCERT maths chapter in order, and pairs each of four AI chapters with an ethics theme (CBSE Class 6 Student Handbook).

One limitation applies to everything below. **No sample page or table of contents was obtained for any commercial title.** Several fetches were blocked (Arihant and Kitabkopy returned HTTP 429, Amazon returned 503), so content claims rest on listings and marketing.

Table 8. Printed books competing for the CT&AI line, 2026-27

Title (publisher)	Classes	Price (Rs)	What the listing shows	Source
CT&AI (OUP India)	3-8	305 (Cl 8, 152 pp)	"All-in-one", matches the hours; no coding, projects, rubrics, teacher or digital layer stated	OUP
Think Smart (Goyal)	3-8	~145-165 (3-5); 270-295 (6-8)	E-book edition; Merit Box app, LMS, QR codes and "AI Buddy" across Goyal's list; Class 7-8 ISBNs fail the check digit	Merit Box; BuyBooksIndia
CT&AI Textbook (Arihant)	6	Unknown	Page blocked; Arihant's house style is question banks	Arihant
Mastering CT & AI (APC; Vidhi Singhal)	6-8	295 (Cl 7)	Author runs an unplugged-CT company; launched at teacher workshops	Amazon.in; LinkedIn
Workbooks (Thinking Juggernaut)	3-8	499-599 (page contradicts itself)	Unpriced AI kit with flashcards, online assessment and a teacher module	Thinking Juggernaut
Tekie.AI Accelerate (Uolo)	4-8	579-629 (booklist)	Book plus platform, under "Computational Thinking & ICT"	CMS booklist
***Not CT&AI:* Goyal AI (901)**	6-8	MRP 450-515	Teacher's resource book, QR worksheets; a skill-subject book often confused with CT&AI	Merit Box
***Not CT&AI:* Orange Touchpad AI**	6	289 (MRP 340)	Skill subject 901	Orange catalogue

Orange's real threat is its general Grades 1-8 computer series. A single book already bundles a "Computational Thinking" strand with Scratch, Python and AI. Behind it sits an Orange-wide teacher package: test generator, lesson plans, "Mini LMS", app and "Capstone Project". Orange also claims "more than 4000 workshops" last year (Orange Catalogue 2026-27). No 2026-27 CT&AI title was found from Kips, Cordova, Rachna Sagar or Madhubun. They will most likely arrive for 2027-28, though that is an inference from their absence.

Platforms assume devices, connectivity or a lab

Table 9. School platforms and programmes

Product	Model and price	What it contains	Fit with CBSE CT&AI
Uolo Tekie	From Rs 799/student/yr	Storytelling books, coding platform "accessible from home", robotics projects, auto-graded homework, test generator, training; claims 500K students in 1,000+ schools	Direct rival, but books carry ICSE and NEP labels and no offline use is stated (Uolo; Issuu)
LEAD CCS	Whole-school subscription	Scratch Jr to Python, a 26-week programme	Needs 1 PC per 2-3 students and teachers with a BCA, MCA or equivalent diploma for Classes 6-8 (LEAD)
STEMpedia PictoBlox	Free app; 6-kit pack USD 1,349	Block and Python coding, image, pose and audio ML; 0.5-0.9M Android installs	Aligned to the Coding skill subject; hardware-led (STEMpedia; AppBrain)
STEMROBO	Kits, labs, "AI Connect" platform	Unplugged in 3-5, ML and AI project lifecycle in 6-8	Closest progression on paper; no prices (STEMROBO)
Ulipsu	Scheduled subject	Projects plus 1,000-1,200 tracked touchpoints per student a year	Profiling is a DPDP liability (Tribune, sponsored)
Codingal, BrightChamps	Own teachers or training	Dashboards, certificates	Outsourced-teacher model (Codingal)
Extramarks, Teachmint	Smart class, panels	Offline *tests* only	Compete for the digital budget (Extramarks)
Code.org, CSpathshala, Experience AI	Free	Code.org: Grades 3-8 curriculum in Hindi and four other languages, 2.2M Indian accounts	Content, not a classroom system (Code.org India)

Uolo is the rival to plan around. It raised **USD 7M in December 2025** (Outlook Business). Its FY24 loss was **Rs 58.1 crore on about Rs 27.9 crore of revenue** (TheKredible; Indian Startup Times). It can afford to discount school by school in 2026-27. LEAD is larger, with **FY26 revenue of Rs 387 crore and a loss of Rs 34.5 crore** (YourStory; Inc42), but it sells a whole-school system, not a CT&AI line.

The open gap is CBSE's own unfinished layer

Table 10. What CBSE asks for, what the market shows, and the opening

CBSE design	What rivals show publicly	CodeSchool opening
3-5 CT inside Maths and TWAU periods, keyed to NCERT chapters	Books follow the chapter order but show no coding or puzzles mapped to it	Chapter-indexed activities with optional coding
40 project hours with rubrics "coming soon"	Orange's catalogue-wide "Capstone"; PiyushAI claims rubrics but lists no prices (PiyushAI)	Ready project kits and rubrics, re-mapped when CBSE publishes its list
"Largely unplugged", no computer needed for assessment	Platforms assume devices or labs	Kits plus projector mode on shared devices, working offline
Assessment by presentations and reflective journals	Auto-graded homework (Tekie)	A competency journal and report-card export
Children's data duties from May 2027	No vendor page states DPDP readiness	Processor-only design, published price

On the evidence, the opening is real. The evidence shows absence, not proof: it holds until someone opens the books. Only 36.5% of schools have a working desktop (EdTechReview), which keeps the unplugged kit relevant well beyond CodeSchool's first market.

What to confirm before December specimens

Table 11. Prioritised checks

#	Confirm	Why it matters	Rough cost or effort
1	Written quotes from 3 offset printers (Delhi-NCR, Sivakasi) for 112 pp A4 four-colour at 2k/5k/10k/20k, printer-supplied paper; plus 64-80 pp option	Print is modelled, not quoted; run length swings it Rs 38-90	2 weeks
2	Terms from 3-5 distributors and booksellers in two target cities: discount, credit days, return cap; ask in the principal interviews too	The 50% central assumption drives the whole verdict	Interviews already scheduled
3	A chartered accountant's opinion on: workbook under 4901; kit under 9503/9504/4819; mixed vs composite supply; inclusive MRP; 18% licence; input credit split	Rs 21-29 a pack at stake, about the central contribution	Rs 15,000-40,000 (est.)
4	Buy OUP, Goyal, Arihant and APC Class 6-7 books (about Rs 1,200), a Tekie.AI Accelerate book and an Orange computer book; request specimens	No rival sample was inspected; the gap claim depends on it	Rs 2,500 and one week
5	Kit prototype quotes: mat, cards, cipher wheels, box, kitting labour; a durability test over one term	Kit life decides Rs 15 vs Rs 69 per student	Rs 20,000-50,000 (est.)
6	3-5 illustrator or studio quotes, and one writer's per-chapter rate	Largest uncertainty in the Rs 25-75 lakh content budget	2 weeks
7	Two agency platform quotes against an in-house plan; one VAPT quote	Rs 20-73 lakh platform range	3 weeks
8	ISBN registration with the Raja Rammohun Roy National Agency for ISBN (believed free, not verified)	Jabalpur FIRs cited fake or duplicate ISBNs	1 week
9	Pilot actuals: specimen sets and visits per conversion; training hours per school	Replaces the unsourced sales and training lines	Through the pilot

Conclusion

The research shifts CodeSchool's financial question from price to route to market. Rs 449 and Rs 599 sit sensibly between OUP's plain book and Tekie's platform. But the default book trade, plus the commissions regulators are now prosecuting, would take most of the margin those prices create. The Offline Programme works only if CodeSchool behaves less like a publisher pushing through distributors and more like a supplier with a published price. That means appointed booksellers, firm per-school quantities, durable kits and cheap cluster training. The compliance advantage and the margin advantage turn out to be the same decision.

The second implication is about sequencing. Per student, the Online licence earns about Rs 150 to the Offline pack's Rs 15-40 on default terms. It also avoids the five-month bookseller cycle, but it reaches only connected schools and costs a platform build first. A sensible plan is to price both now, pilot the Offline pack on re-engineered terms in a small number of schools, and treat the first year as paid research. The year should answer three questions: what the channel really takes, how long a kit survives, and how much training a school needs. Those three numbers, not the MRP, decide whether CodeSchool is a business.

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